Bolshevism filling that void.[81] Cox also justified his continued political support for the established Russian diplomats by pointing out that should such support be withdrawn, these Russians would soon be ousted by Bolshevik emissaries.[82] While Cox would have liked to have seen the tsarist element in Persia replaced by a British presence, he certainly did not want it exchanged for Bolshevik officials. In Mallet's eyes, however, the solution was simply for Britain to make sure it filled the vacuum itself, arguing that 'there is little to be gained by maintaining Russian interest in N. Persia against Persian wishes'.[83] For Montagu, keeping Russian diplomatic figures afloat was advisable, but he questioned the wisdom of aiding Russia to hold on to its economic interests in Persia.[84] Others in the India Office simply believed that 'this appears to be a quite impossible line of policy'.[85] Oliphant agreed that 'there seems no need to bolster up Russian political interests'.[86] Yet, in January 1918 Oliphant had admitted that in Persia, 'anything is better than Bolshevism',[87] and so for now, maintaining the Russian Legation and the Cossack Division appeared to carry less risk than the potential consequences of breaking with them.

It would seem, then, that the policy that Curzon and his allies were pursuing in Persia in 1918–1919 consisted of supporting one group of Russians against the possible threat of another group, while all the while working to at least undermine, if not remove, Russian influence altogether in that country, to be replaced by a British presence forced upon the Persian government through economic coercion. This was a policy that the Indian government vocally opposed. By April 1919, Chelmsford was arguing that the 'existence of anti-British feeling among Moslems in Egypt and India... coupled with unsettled condition of Afghanistan, renders the present a highly dangerous moment for initiation of so hazardous an experiment'.[88] In February 1919, the emir of Afghanistan, Habibullah, had been assassinated, sparking a succession crisis,[89] while in India Chelmsford was facing rising popular unrest following the enactment of the Rowlatt Bill and the infamous Amritsar Massacre on 13 April.[90] While they were struggling to keep a check on events within India itself, the viceroy and his government were cautious of giving Muslims in South Asia any further excuse for agitation.